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Beyond IQ and EQ: Is there a Missing Dimension?

Body Intelligence and the way leaders show up

What is BQ?

We have learned to value **IQ** — how leaders think — and **EQ** — how leaders understand and respond to emotions. Could there be another dimension worth thinking about: **BQ, the Body Quotient**?

I define **BQ** as the awareness and intentional use of our physical presence, energy, composure, body language and everyday behaviour in the way we lead and interact with others.

It is not about physical health

BQ might easily be interpreted as physical health or fitness. Nutrition and physical wellbeing matter, but BQ is primarily about **body behaviour**: how our physical presence and behaviour affect the people around us.

How do IQ, EQ and BQ interact?

IQ helps us know what to do; **EQ** helps us understand how people feel; **BQ** influences how people experience us while we do it.

BQ complements IQ and EQ. It is the physical expression through which much of our intelligence and emotional awareness becomes visible. A leader may understand that people matter and genuinely empathize with them. But if that leader rarely leaves the office, appears hurried when approached, avoids eye contact or becomes visibly agitated under pressure, people may experience that leader quite differently.

BQ in everyday leadership

Earlier in my career, a board member visiting one of the businesses I led commented that people seemed positive and motivated. I explained that most mornings, I would walk through the facilities, stop for conversations and ask team members about their work — and often about them personally. I learned things I would never have learned through meetings or reports, and people knew I was interested and cared.

Of course, we all have bad mornings. BQ does not mean performing artificial positivity. As leaders, we can be conscious of — and choose — the energy and attitude we bring into a room and to the people around us.

BQ when the pressure is on

During difficult times, employees watch the leader closely, often before the leader even speaks. Visible frustration, nervous energy or agitation can travel through an organization remarkably

quickly. In difficult situations, I always aimed to remain calm, positive and empathetic, while focusing the team on understanding the issue and solving it together.

This is where EQ and BQ meet. We may *feel* empathy, but people experience it through our voice, facial expression, posture, patience and behaviour.

So, is BQ really another dimension?

For many, much of this may sound obvious. Good leaders practise elements of BQ instinctively without ever giving it a name. For others, it may offer a useful opportunity to reflect on how they show up and how their behaviour is experienced by those around them.

Whether we choose to think of BQ as a distinct dimension may be less important than the underlying idea. Leaders are not experienced through their intellect or emotional awareness alone. They are experienced through their presence, energy and behaviour — especially in moments when they are not “consciously leading.”

These seemingly small behaviours can have an outsized impact on **culture, motivation** and ultimately **performance**.

So perhaps a **few questions** worth asking ourselves are:

- Do I make time to be present where the work happens?
- How do people feel after interacting with me?
- When pressure rises, what do people see from me?
- Does my body language match the culture I want to create?